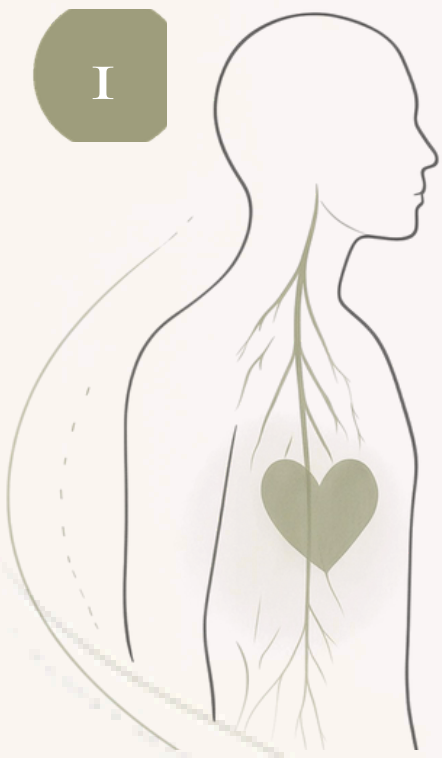
YOUR NERVOUS SYSTEM

How the autonomic nervous system shifts with safety, challenge and threat

WHAT IS THE VAGUS NERVE?

A major communication pathway linking the brainstem with the heart, lungs and digestive system. It helps coordinate parasympathetic functions involved in heart rate, digestion, recovery and regulation.



1

CONNECT & ENGAGE

relative safety

Body

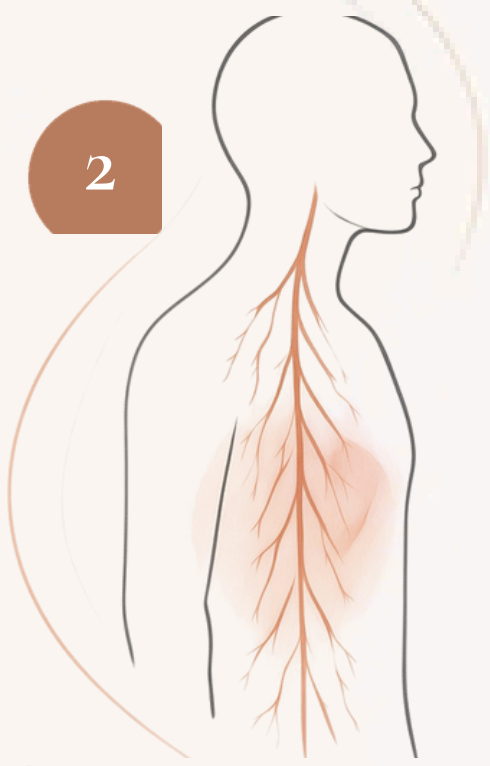
- relaxed, open posture
- steady breath & heart rate
- comfortable energy
- body feels safe enough to settle

Mind

- clear and curious
- able to focus and learn
- flexible thinking
- access to perspective
- sense of possibility

Relationships

- connection feels possible
- empathy and trust
- mutuality and safety
- collaboration, play & closeness



2

MOBILIZE

sympathetic activation and fight-flight energy

Body

- heart rate and breath increase
- muscles prepare for action
- adrenaline and energy rise
- body becomes alert & mobilized

Mind

- heightened awareness
- racing or urgent thoughts
- worry and threat scanning
- narrowed focus
- need to act or escape

Relationships

- may pull away or push back
- less patience
- stronger protective boundaries
- conflict can feel more likely



3

IMMOBILIZE

protective shutdown or reduced activation

Body

- low energy or numbness
- heavy, tired or frozen
- breath may become shallow
- body conserves energy

Mind

- foggy or blank
- difficult to concentrate
- low motivation or hopelessness
- feeling disconnected from self

Relationships

- withdraw or isolate
- harder to reach for support
- may feel unseen or alone
- little capacity to engage



WINDOW OF TOLERANCE
Your workable range of arousal—enough capacity to feel, think, connect and choose. Above = hyperarousal. Below = hypoarousal.

BUILD VAGAL FLEXIBILITY:
• longer exhales • rhythmic movement • humming or singing • safe connection • sleep & recovery • mindfulness • nature • regular movement.

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